Is the U.S. Freight Recovery Real?

Analysis as of 2026-11-03 UTC | Edition freight-2026-11-03-r3
Public-source research sample | Primary fieldwork proposed

Ex-fuel rates have improved; a broad, demand-led freight recovery remains unconfirmed.

01 | Demand

Truck tonnage -1.6% YoY (2026-08); Cass shipments +1.9% YoY (2026-09); Freight Transportation Services Index -3.0% YoY (2026-08). [1] [2] [3]

Read shipment activity separately from nominal spending. These series cover different periods and segments; they are not a single contemporaneous demand measure.

02 | Pricing

Cass ex-fuel linehaul 154.8, +10.1% YoY and +0.6% MoM (2026-09). Truckload PPI +17.9% YoY; diesel-model residual -9.7pp (2026-09). [4] [5] [6]

Direct ex-fuel rate growth and a negative model residual can coexist: the residual is deviation from a historical fit, not observed rate growth. Cass blends spot/contract dry-van invoices by processing month; demand versus capacity effects remain unresolved.

03 | Company conversion

Q2 2026 GAAP operating-margin changes, YoY: KNX +1.1pp [7], SNDR +0.7pp [8], WERN -7.0pp [9]. Mean -1.7pp, median +0.7pp; mean excluding WERN +0.9pp.

The negative mean is WERN-sensitive, so operating leverage is mixed. Werner's company-reported adjusted operating margin rose 0.8pp YoY; its release identifies prior-year liability reversals. [10] Retain all peers and GAAP inputs; review adjusted definitions and segment mix separately.

Alternative explanations

• Fuel, freight mix and contract-reset timing can move headline prices. A diesel regression residual does not isolate their separate effects.
• Acquisitions, segment mix and cost timing can explain company margin differences. Consolidated results do not establish pricing power.

What I would investigate next

1. **Test durability and mechanism.** Track Cass linehaul and matched spot/contract rates with shipment activity across further releases; distinguish demand growth from capacity exits.

2. **Explain profit conversion.** Extend Werner's GAAP/adjusted reconciliation to all peers on consistent definitions; check segment volumes, ex-fuel yield and acquisition mix.

3. **Challenge the view in calls.** Ask private shippers, fleet owners and brokers about comparable operations, then cross-check first-hand observations and disagreements. Fieldwork is planned, not completed.

Project leadership & AI tools

I led and carried out this project end to end, owning the research question, indicator selection, data workflow, evidence assessment and final conclusions. Following review, I revised the analysis to incorporate direct rate evidence and peer sensitivity checks.
I used AI as a tool for source discovery, coding and drafting. Research design, evidence assessment and final conclusions remained my responsibility. No primary interviews have been completed; source checks are selective and do not constitute a full independent audit.

Sources | links lead to the original series or filing

[1] Truck Tonnage Index
[2] Cass Freight Index: Shipments
[3] Freight Transportation Services Index
[4] Cass Truckload Linehaul Index - September 2026
[5] Fuel-adjusted residual: Truckload PPI (long-distance)
[6] US Diesel Sales Price
[7] Knight-Swift Transportation 10-Q (filed 2026-07-29)
[8] Schneider National 10-Q (filed 2026-07-31)
[9] Werner Enterprises 10-Q (filed 2026-08-07)
[10] Werner Q2 2026 results and GAAP / non-GAAP reconciliation

Independent public-data writing sample. No primary interviews are included. Observation periods differ; source figures and statistical proxies do not establish causality. No consensus expectations or investment recommendation is asserted.

Fixed information cutoff: 2026-11-03T06:22:00.000Z. Macro retrieved 2026-11-03 | SEC retrieved 2026-11-01 | Prices retrieved 2026-11-01. Observation periods shown above.